

Caretaker Diary: The Life of Sugni Devi

(Comprehensive Log: Jan 2025 – Nov 2025)

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Page 1 – January 12, 2025

Sugni wakes slowly now. She reaches for the radio more than the clock; sometimes the songs bring her back to mornings on her mother's verandah in Lucknow. I sit with her at the kitchen table while she sips her *adrak chai* (ginger tea). She calls me "Anju" sometimes—a nickname from long ago—and laughs when I remind her we met through the agency, not at a cousin's wedding.

She was born March 3, 1945, in Lucknow, just before Independence, to Meera and Hari Singh. She always said her father taught her the value of books and cloth; he was a weaver who repaired old harmoniums in the evenings.

She has fragments today: the smell of cardamom reminds her of the staff room at the school, and then she asks where the brass prayer lamp went. I write these tiny wins down in the blue notebook beside her favorite cane chair. She used to be a Headmistress at Government Girls' High School for 30 years—proud of her stern but fair reputation and the library she fought to get funded, which she jokes "never had enough books."

She married Ramesh Kumar in 1970; they had two children: Guddi (b. 1974) and Suresh (b. 1977). Ramesh's old letters are still kept folded in a tin box in the top drawer—she likes to hold the paper on heavy afternoons.

Medical Note: Diagnosed with early-onset Alzheimer's nine years ago (2016), but symptoms accelerated in 2023. Currently on donepezil and memantine; sleep disturbed, daytime confusion increased.

Small Memory: Today she recited the first line of a poem her father loved: "*The path of truth is difficult, but the destination is sweet.*" She smiled and asked if the Gomti river still flowed the same way.

Page 2 – February 6, 2025

We walked slowly to the neighborhood park this morning. She recognized the old Peepal tree at the corner and wanted to sit on the bench under it "like Sundays long ago." She told me about making mango pickles with her brother, Mohan, describing how they would guard the drying jars from crows on the roof and laugh for hours. I prompted with photos from the album; the image of her in a stiff cotton saree sparked a 10-minute recollection—it was from the day she first took charge as Vice-Principal.

She sometimes confuses names: Suresh becomes "Suru from the sweet shop" and Guddi is "the girl with the braided hair." When I ask about work, she speaks of chalk dust and the sound of the morning assembly bell, using English grammar terms that surprise me—traces of the teacher remain.

She knows melodies, though, better than anything. We played old songs by Lata Mangeshkar from the 1960s; she tapped the table to the beat and said, "We listened to this in '71 at Ramesh's sister's engagement." I asked about Ramesh; she grew quiet and said, "He used to hum while reading the newspaper." There was a softness in her eyes.

Important Facts Observed: Birthday celebrations were modest, usually a simple *puja* at home. She had a close friendship with a fellow teacher, Shanti, who later moved to Delhi (Shanti called every year on Sugni's birthday; last call recorded in 2018). Sugni's favorite dessert is *Gajar ka Halwa* (carrot pudding)—she requests it for festivals.

Behavioral Note: Anxiety spikes around crowded markets; responds well to rhythmic music (Bhajans or Old Classics) and familiar smells (incense, camphor, frying spices).

Page 3 – March 21, 2025

Today's entry is shorter—fog in her mind, but warm pockets of clarity. She remembered teaching Suresh to ride a scooter in the empty ground near the temple. She described the way she held the handle and how she ran behind with a laugh when Suresh accelerated faster than expected. I could see pride in her; parental memories seem resilient.

She speaks less about her career now and more about small kindnesses: the rickshaw puller who would wait an extra minute for her on rainy days, the neighbor Mrs. Gupta who shared spinach from her garden. She sometimes calls Guddi by her childhood nickname, "Gudiya," and worries aloud that she has misplaced "the register"—though naming which register proves impossible.

Medical/Administrative Facts for RAG Graph:

- Primary Physician: Dr. A. Kapoor, City Geriatrics.
- Emergency Contact: Guddi (Daughter).
- Insurance: Central Govt Health Scheme (CGHS), beneficiary since 2005.
- Allergies: Sulfa drugs (mild rash reported in 1998).

Care Notes: Respond to disorientation by offering a tactile object (her wooden prayer beads) and a guiding sentence: "You are safe, Ma-ji; we are in the kitchen, and it is a Wednesday morning." This often reduces agitation in under 5 minutes.

Page 4 – April 8, 2025

Today was a difficult afternoon. She woke believing she needed to catch a train to the village to see her father. I reminded her gently that Hari Singh passed in 1989 and that the old station has changed. She became agitated, saying she couldn't miss the train.

I used the photo album again—images of family, the wedding mandap, and children's birthdays—and eventually she calmed, expressing a simple regret: "I wanted to tell him I taught the children well." We talked about blessings and duty. She asked me if she had ever been brave; I told her about the time she stood up to the school board to keep the girls' scholarship fund active. She smiled and said, "I must've been stubborn then."

Personal Relationships: Strained relationship with her brother Mohan after a property dispute in 1992; however, later reconciliation is recorded in letters from 2000. Ramesh passed away in 2015—funeral notes mention a eulogy by Guddi.

Routine Note: Implement an orientation board in her room (Date, Day, Photo of Family) and a scheduled mid-afternoon nap to reduce sundowning effects. She benefits from one-on-one conversation rather than group activities.

Page 5 – May 2, 2025

May feels like a bridge between seasons, the heat rising. Sugni spent part of the morning describing the smell of her mother's kitchen—mustard oil and cumin—and then switched to telling a story about a small stationery shop in Aminabad where she bought her first fountain pen. She laughed remembering how heavy it felt compared to the ballpoints she used later.

The afternoon was calm; she corrected the grammar on a newspaper headline with a red pen—the teacher in her hands remembers form and syntax even when words fail.

Legacy Notes (Useful Nodes for Knowledge Graph):

- **Full Name:** Sugni Devi
- **DOB:** March 3, 1945
- **Birthplace:** Lucknow, Uttar Pradesh, India
- **Spouse:** Ramesh Kumar (m. 1970–2015)
- **Children:** Guddi (b. 1974), Suresh (b. 1977)
- **Grandchildren:** Khushi (Guddi's daughter), Sahil & Garima (Suresh's children)
- **Sibling:** Mohan Singh (brother)
- **Occupation:** Headmistress, Government Girls' High School (approx. 1969–1999)
- **Hobbies:** Reading poetry, gardening, listening to Gazals/Old Hindi songs
- **Medical:** Alzheimer's disease / dementia diagnosis 2016.
- **Preferences:** Gajar ka Halwa, Adrak Chai, Old Bollywood music, open verandahs.

Final Caregiver Reflection (Part 1): Sugni is more than a list of symptoms. She is a woman whose hands remember what her mind sometimes forgets: how to grade a paper, how to bless a child, how to light a lamp. My role is to collect these traces.

Page 6 – May 27, 2025

This morning Guddi visited with her daughter, Khusi (Sugni's granddaughter, age 9). The moment Khusi entered, Sugni brightened. She called her "Choti Gudiya," confusing her with Guddi's childhood self, but when Khusi showed her a drawing of a peacock, Sugni laughed and said, "You have the artist's hand, unlike your mother." Guddi grew emotional; she whispered to me that Khusi never really knew her grandfather Ramesh, but Sugni still compares the girl's eyes to Ramesh's. Family continuity seems to soothe her.

Later, we spoke about Guddi's school years. Sugni remembered braiding Guddi's hair for dance recitals, though she misplaced the location (she said Delhi instead of Lucknow). She also mentioned Guddi winning a debate competition, recalling a silver trophy—though Guddi corrected that it was Suresh's cricket trophy. The family gathers around her memories, correcting gently, filling gaps without judgment.

Note: She responds strongly to grandchildren. Recommend increasing family visits, especially one-on-one with Khusi, as these exchanges spark joy and recognition.

Page 7 – June 14, 2025

Suresh came by today. Mother and son share a quieter bond, but Suresh's voice seems to ground Sugni. They discussed summer holidays from decades ago. Sugni remembered a story of Suresh eating too many mangoes and getting a stomach ache, exaggerating playfully, and Suresh laughed, adding details about how she scolded him while feeding him plain curd and rice. Shared humor remains a strong connection.

We also touched on career memories. Suresh asked Sugni how she managed the school timetable. Surprisingly, Sugni explained the logic of rotating periods and teacher assignments with clarity for a full three minutes. Suresh recorded this moment, saying, "Ma, you're still the boss." Sugni's pride showed; she said softly, "Someone had to keep order."

Behavioral Observation: Discussions that combine humor + professional/technical prompts (school management) anchor her attention longest (7–10 minutes sustained focus). Suresh's presence reduces agitation; his visits should continue biweekly.

Page 8 – July 9, 2025

The family hosted a small get-together at Guddi's house. Sugni attended for two hours before becoming fatigued. She recognized her brother Mohan almost immediately, despite years apart. They embraced, and Sugni said, "We let the tea get cold, didn't we?" (Meaning they waited too long). Mohan responded, "We are drinking it now, Didi." This was a breakthrough—Sugni has referred to herself as "Didi" (sister) occasionally, her old role in the family.

She also mistook a cousin, Anju, for a former colleague. This caused brief distress until Guddi gently reminded her. She calmed when Mohan began humming an old folk song from their village; soon Sugni joined in, singing the chorus about the rain and the harvest. Music once again bridged the gaps.

Observation: Large gatherings risk overstimulation, but short, structured reunions are valuable. Strong musical anchors should be incorporated into group events.

Page 9 – August 1, 2025

Sugni woke asking about her wedding. I brought out the red velvet album, and she lingered over the image of herself in the heavy bridal saree. She told me she “wore anklets that were too heavy” and remembered the sound of rain on the tent during the pheras. She touched the photo and said, “Best day, even with the mud.” Her memory for emotional events is vivid.

Later that afternoon, Khusi returned with a school assignment—an interview about family history. She asked Sugni what life was like when she was a girl. Sugni spoke about playing *Pithoo* (Seven Stones) in the lanes, about the *kulfi* wallah ringing his bell at dusk, and about her mother drying chilies on the terrace. Khusi wrote every word down, her eyes wide. Sugni seemed proud, as though passing wisdom forward.

Reflection: These intergenerational exchanges create a living bridge between Sugni’s past and Khusi’s present. Recommend encouraging Khusi to continue these interviews; Sugni thrives when given a purposeful role.

Page 10 – August 22, 2025

Today, Sugni asked about her retirement. She remembered leaving the school gates, recalling the garland of marigolds the students placed around her neck. She said, “They sang ‘Vande Mataram’ for me, Anju—even the peon cried.” She chuckled at the thought. Then she looked serious: “Did I teach them enough?” I assured her that hundreds of students, her children, and a life of service were proof of more than enough. She smiled, repeating, “A good journey.”

In the evening, she became disoriented, believing she had to go to the staff meeting. Suresh arrived unexpectedly and reassured her, saying, “Ma, school is closed for the holidays.” They sat quietly, listening to old Ghazals. Sugni tapped her fingers on the armrest, eyes half-closed, at peace.

Closing Caregiver Reflection: Sugni’s story is layered with discipline, family, music, and reconciliation. My role continues to remind her she has already built her legacy.

Page 11 – September 10, 2025

This morning Sugni asked about school inspection again. She insisted the inspector was coming, and I gently reminded her those days were long past. To redirect, I showed her Guddi's old report cards. She smiled at the signatures, pointing to one and saying, "That's Gudiya—she had the best handwriting in the class." She mixed timelines, but the pride was genuine.

Later, she talked about her own schooling: a strict teacher named Masterji who made her memorize Sanskrit shlokas. She recited one line: "*Knowledge gives humility.*" I couldn't verify the exact text, so perhaps it was her memory shaping words anew.

In the afternoon, neighbor Mrs. Gupta visited. She has known Sugni for decades and brought fresh *Mathri* (crackers). Sugni recognized her instantly, calling her "Shanti" (confusing her with the old friend). They spoke of Diwali parties in the 1980s, how everyone lit lamps on the walls. She grew animated, describing sparklers and children running. These visits with old neighbors spark familiarity—perhaps more than family, because they anchor her in the physical neighborhood.

Page 12 – September 29, 2025

A rare outing today: we took Sugni to the riverbank (Ghats). The smell of damp earth and incense made her emotional. She told me, "This is the smell of home." She remembered taking boat rides with her father, laughing when the boat rocked. She asked if Mohan still had the old shawl; I explained it had been years, but she nodded as if satisfied. For lunch, she wanted *Jalebi*, though she only ate a few bites. Still, the act of holding the sticky sweet seemed to comfort her.

Later, Suresh joined us and played a recording of Sugni's voice from years back—an old cassette of her giving a speech at the school Annual Day. Sugni listened carefully and then said, "She knew what she was saying." Suresh replied, "That was you, Ma." Sugni laughed: "I was stricter then."

Observation: Sensory environments (river, incense, familiar foods, recorded voices) open deep wells of memory. Recommend monthly trips to the river or temple if possible.

Page 13 – October 18, 2025

The day began with confusion—Sugni insisted Ramesh was still alive and waiting in the courtyard for his tea. When she saw the empty chair, she grew distressed. I comforted her with their wedding album. After a while, she said, "He was patient with my temper," and tears came. Guddi called, and I put her on speaker. Sugni told her, "Your father is reading the paper right now." Guddi responded gently, "Yes, Ma, I can almost hear the rustle of the pages." This calmed her. Their shared imagination became a safe bridge.

In the evening, Khusi visited again. She brought school homework and asked Sugni to help with a Hindi grammar problem. Sugni surprised us all by correcting the sentence structure perfectly, explaining the rule like a teacher. Khusi clapped, and Sugni said, "I am still useful."

Reflection: When family members enter her reality rather than correcting it, peace is restored more quickly. Encourage training family on supportive dialogue.

Page 14 – November 7, 2025

Sugni attended the evening Aarti at the local Hanuman Mandir with me. The Bhajans were instantly familiar; she sang every verse of "Jai Jagdish Hare" without pause. Fellow devotees, many of whom remembered her as 'Headmistress Madam', welcomed her warmly. She folded her hands, repeating, "I used to check your uniforms," which drew laughter. Music, ritual, and faith community seem to connect her to long-standing identity roles.

Later that week, her grandson Sahil and granddaughter Garima (Suresh's children) visited with Mohan. They played Ludo, though Sugni struggled with rules. Mohan adapted, letting Sugni move pieces freely. At one point Sugni moved her token incorrectly and said, "This one wants to fly home early." They both laughed. Even in errors, creativity surfaces.

Care Note: Religious settings and old friendships provide grounding. Encourage occasional visits to the Mandir, but only for shorter durations to avoid fatigue.

Page 15 – November 28, 2025

A family gathering for a late-year feast (post-Diwali celebration) at Guddi's home. The table was filled with family. Sugni ate little, but her joy was visible. She called out to Khushi, "Pass the Kheer," though none was on the table—Guddi quickly brought out a bowl she had prepared just for her. Sugni smiled and said, "Now it is a real festival."

During dinner, Suresh asked Sugni about her first job. She described working as a tuition teacher, remembering the sound of cycling on the cobblestones of old Lucknow. She told a story about walking through mud to reach a student's house and being given a glass of cold *Sherbet* by the mother. The detail delighted everyone. Khushi wrote it down for her school project.

Closing Note: Festivals anchor Sugni in ritual and taste. Kheer, Bhajans, river air—these are threads of her life story. My role remains: to weave them together so her legacy endures beyond memory's erosion.